



using curative substances that were similar to the perceived cause of the ailment, such as dung to alleviate gut problems.

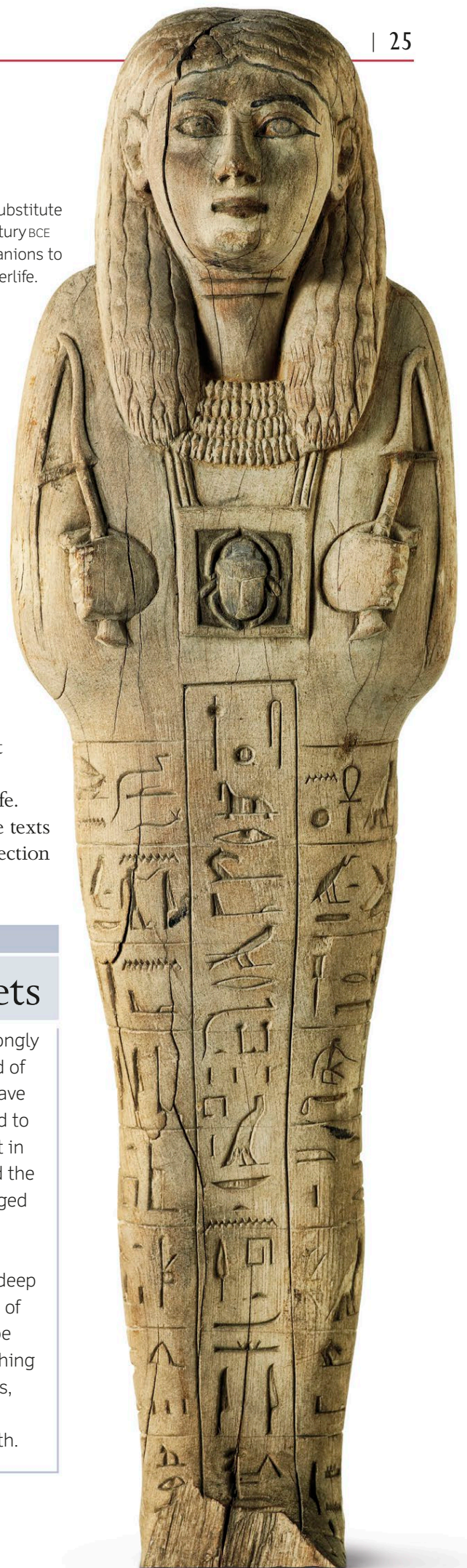
Magicians used spells either as a direct measure, such as “ordering” a stuck bone to leave the patient’s throat, or indirectly, for instance, telling the spirit (often identified as a foreign demon) responsible for the illness to leave the sick person. Amulets were also placed on afflicted parts of the body or used to stave off illness.

► Wooden mummy shabti

At first figurines like this acted as a substitute for the deceased, but by the 16th century BCE they were seen as workers and companions to provide for the dead person in the afterlife.

Death was the greatest challenge. Observances on behalf of the dead were elaborate, at least for the elite, and aimed to unite the *ka* and *ba*, the two parts of the soul, in death. Incantations and mummification were carried out to protect the *ka*, the life source, and to release the *ba*, which contained a person’s character, on its journey to the underworld.

For kings, Pyramid Texts, written down from the 27th century BCE, let their souls fight demons, pay off otherworldly boatmen, and reach the next life. It was another 600 years before texts appeared offering magical protection to a wider section of society.



THOTH

Holder of magic secrets

Thoth, the god of wisdom and writing, was strongly associated with magic. Depicted with the head of a baboon or an ibis (as here), he was said to have invented the hieroglyphic script, which he used to write 42 secret books of wisdom that were kept in temples. He was also believed to have restored the left eye of Horus (the moon) after it was damaged by Seth and images of this, called the *wedjat* (sound eye), were considered to possess great magical power. Thoth also journeyed into the deep desert to retrieve the eye of Ra, which the king of the gods needed to see, and acted as the scribe of the underworld, recording the result of weighing a deceased person’s sins. Hermes Trismegistus, the Thrice Great magician of later Greek and Roman myth, is said to have derived from Thoth.